family were removed from their home and told they had to leave most of their belongings behind. After spending five months in makeshift, cordoned-off containment facilities at Santa Anita racetrack, they were moved to the Poston 3 Relocation Camp in the Arizona desert. Tajiri later recalled of the camp facility in which his family were forced to live: “Encircled with barbed wire and watch towers with machine guns. … we were imprisoned, our freedom denied.”[4] Months later, after being given an option to join the war effort to gain freedom from the camp, Tajiri enlisted.[5] He went through basic training in Shelby, Mississippi, a town under Jim Crow rule, and joined the 442nd Regimental Combat Team of Nisei soldiers.

On May 1, 1944, Tajiri shipped out to Europe with his segregated unit, led by white officers.[6] Shortly thereafter, he was seriously wounded in combat in Italy. After a six-month convalescence, he was transferred to limited service and worked as an army artist in a village near Mannheim, Germany, where he drew portraits of detained political opponents of the Nazis for the army. He identified with such a category of “displaced persons.” After an honorable discharge in 1946 and a brief stint spent studying at the Art Institute of Chicago, he decided to leave the United States rather than contend with postwar racial aggression against Japanese Americans. Tajiri recalled, “I reminded people of their recent enemy.”[7] In 1948, he received GI bill support for art study in Paris and left the U.S. without a plan for permanent return. In Paris, he studied with Fernand Legér and Ossip Zadkine. He later moved to Amsterdam, ultimately settling with his family in Baarlo, where they purchased an old village castle, refurbished the historic building’s crumbled sections, and placed his studio in one of its wings. Other than occasional family visits and brief arts residencies, he never again lived in the United States.

In October 1969, Tajiri accepted an invitation to meet with officials about a guest professorship at the Hochschule der Künste in West Berlin. He was summoned at the request of students who had seen his work at the prominent Documenta IV arts festival in Kassel, Germany, the year prior, at one of the international art world’s most prominent venues, and petitioned him to join the faculty. Tajiri accepted the position under unorthodox conditions: he would teach almost continuously for two weeks a month, live in a tent in his studio, and make himself readily available to students (fig. 3.1). The other two weeks, he would return to Baarlo and family and work on larger commissions. Tajiri’s own reasons for accepting this position in West Berlin